

Policy

Office/Contact: Vice President of Technology/CIO

Sources/Links:

Federal Laws, Regulations, and Standards for Accessibility

- [The Americans with Disabilities Act of 1990 \(ADA\)](#)
- [Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act of 1973](#)
- [Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act](#)
- [Section 508 Training, Tools and Events](#)
- [21st Century Communications and Video Accessibility Act \(CVAA\)](#)
- [World Wide Web Consortium's Web Content Accessibility Guidelines \(WCAG\)](#)

NORTHERN STATE UNIVERSITY

Policies and Guidelines

SUBJECT: Digital Accessibility Policy

NUMBER: 7:24

1. Purpose

Northern State University is committed to providing an accessible digital experience for all users, including those with disabilities. This policy ensures that all digital content, including websites, mobile apps, learning management systems (LMS), social media, online publications, forms, emails and multimedia, complies with the **Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.1 Level AA**. The university recognizes the importance of accessible digital content in promoting academic success, communication, and equal opportunity for all members of the campus community, including students, faculty, staff, and visitors.

2. Scope

This policy applies to all digital content as described in Section 4.b.

3. Target Audience



This policy applies to all faculty, staff, student employees, affiliates, and volunteers who create digital content as described in Section 4.b.

4. Definitions

a. **WCAG 2.1 (Web Content Accessibility Guidelines 2.1)**

A set of international guidelines developed by the World Wide Web Consortium (W3C) to ensure that web content is accessible to all users, including those with disabilities. WCAG 2.1 builds on WCAG 2.0 and includes new criteria focused on mobile accessibility, low-vision users, and cognitive disabilities. The **Level AA** guidelines, which are the focus of this policy, are those that must be met, in accordance with Title II rules, for a website or digital content to be considered accessible for most users with disabilities.

b. **Digital Content**

used and/or created by the university, including but not limited to:

- i. **Websites:** All public-facing and internal university websites that are managed by the university
- ii. **Mobile Apps:** All university-managed mobile applications.
- iii. **Learning Management Systems (LMS):** Course materials, assignments, and resources.
- iv. **Social Media:** Official university social media accounts and content posted on platforms like Facebook, X, Instagram, SnapChat and YouTube. This also includes social media content integrated into university controlled websites.
- v. **Multimedia:** Lecture capture, university YouTube channels, university podcasts, videoconferencing, digital signage
- vi. **Publications, Documents:** Digital versions of official university publications, flyers, brochures, newsletters, Microsoft files, PDF document, etc.
- vii. **Forms:** Online forms, tickets and surveys, including those used for admissions, registration, and feedback.
- viii. **Email:** All digital correspondence, regardless of whether the audience is known
- ix. **Software:** Locally installed, on-premise, cloud, or Software-as-a-Service (SaaS)

c. **Assistive Technology**

Any device, software, or equipment that helps people with disabilities interact with digital content. Examples include screen readers (for users who are blind or have low vision), voice recognition software (for users with motor impairments), and closed captioning tools (for users who are deaf or hard of hearing).

d. **Learning Management System (LMS)**

A software application used to provide online access to course materials,

assignments, and resources. Northern State University uses D2L Brightspace. All content hosted on the LMS must meet accessibility standards.

e. **Alternative Formats**

Alternative formats refer to different versions of digital content provided to ensure accessibility. For example, offering a Word document instead of a PDF, providing text descriptions of images, or offering video content with audio descriptions or transcripts.

f. **Multimedia**

Digital content that includes any combination of audio, video, text, and/or interactive elements that requires captioning for videos, transcripts for audio, and audio descriptions for visual media to ensure accessibility.

5. Policy

- a. The university adheres to the **WCAG 2.1 Level AA** accessibility guidelines for all digital content.
- b. Responsibilities

University Leadership

- Provide support for accessibility initiatives and allocate resources for compliance efforts.
- Ensure that all departments and units are aware of and adhere to the accessibility guidelines.

Web Team

- Ensure all new and existing websites and mobile applications meet WCAG 2.1 Level AA standards.
- Regularly conduct accessibility audits and usability tests with assistive technology users.
- Implement accessibility improvements and corrections as part of the development lifecycle.

Faculty and Course Designers

- Ensure that all course materials and assignments in the Learning Management System (LMS) are fully accessible.
- Provide students with alternative formats for inaccessible content upon request.

- Follow university accessibility training and use accessible content creation tools for all online teaching resources.

Communications and Marketing

- Ensure that all official university digital publications (e.g., newsletters, flyers, blogs) are accessible, including alt text for images and captioning for videos.
- Ensure that all official university social media posts meet accessibility standards (e.g., alternative text for images, proper hashtags for screen reader users).

IT and Accessibility Services

- Provide guidance on best practices for web and document accessibility.
- Ensure the accessibility of university-provided technologies and platforms under their control.
- Offer training and technical support to staff and faculty on accessibility tools and techniques.
- Conduct regular accessibility audits of university websites, apps, and digital content.

Faculty, Staff, Student Employees, Affiliates and Volunteers

- Be aware of the requirements to meet accessibility requirements (policy, training materials)
- Ensure digital publications (e.g., newsletters, flyers, blogs) are accessible, including alt text for images and captioning for videos.
- Ensure that all social media posts meet accessibility standards (e.g., alternative text for images, proper hashtags for screen reader users).

6. Responsible Administrator

The Vice President of Technology is responsible for annual review of this policy and its procedures.

7. Source History:

- Approval Date: May 5, 2025
- Approved By: Executive Leadership Team
- Review Date: May 5, 2025